



Problems at home and problems with HP

Some readers have pointed out to us that Digit also has problems with service when it comes to delivering subscription copies on time, and a surprising number are having a real struggle with Hewlett-Packard, particularly regarding laptops

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Digit subscriptions

It had to happen. Having started a series of occasional articles on customer service, a few readers have written in to point out that there are times when our service at *Digit* does not meet expectations. This mainly takes the form of the magazine either turning up late or failing to arrive at all for subscribers. Thankfully, there are few of these, but we picked a couple of them, and asked our subscription department to investigate.

G. Kumar wrote from Bangalore to say that he had renewed his subscription, but that the January issue had failed to arrive, even though he did receive the February issue on 31st January. Where the fault lies, we cannot be sure, but to the best of our understanding, the cheque for his subscription renewal was received late — too late in fact for it to clear before the beginning of January, and for this reason he was not on the list for the January issue. A copy has now been sent to him.

It is important to remember when renewing a subscription, that it takes time, both for our subscription department to process the request and also for the banks to clear the cheque. Please be early when renewing.

Another reader, Pratik Gupta, wrote to say that he was also not receiving *Digit*, but he also expressed great frustration in trying to contact us to get help — specifically when calling our helpline. We found that the problem with his copies of *Digit* lay with the courier company that we were using to make the delivery, and as this has now been changed, we hope that he is reading this issue at the very beginning of May. We checked the new courier POD (proof of delivery) for the April issue, and it was delivered correctly on the 1st April.

In general, if you have problems because of either not receiving the magazine, or it is arriving late, please call the helpline, on +91-22-4078 9612 / 13 / 14 — but only in normal office working hours, between 9.30 am and 6.30 pm, Monday to Friday. You can also use email: help@thinkdigit.com. Of course, if all this fails, you can also do what these two readers did, and email us at: servicewatch@thinkdigit.com.

Does Hewlett-Packard have service problems?

Since having suggested to readers that they write to us if they are having some particularly bad support or service experience with a vendor, we have received a steady trickle of emails. Surprisingly, at one point, nine out of the 18 complaints we had received concerned just one company, HP. The ratio is down now, and about 40 per cent concern HP; but this is still far too high. So, is this a statistical cluster, or does HP really have a problem? I am still discussing this with HP, but it seems that the company does have problems that need to be addressed.

Let's take one example, from Manoj Nair in Chennai. He has had repeated problems with his Compaq Presario V3225AU. I spoke to him just before writing this, and he told me that so far his motherboard had been repaired or replaced a total of eight times! He felt very little confidence that his laptop would now be free from problems, particularly because service centre engineers had told him that the particular graphics processor and CPU in this model are not suitable for the Indian market, they are subject to overheating and consequent failure of the motherboard.

He wonders why HP does not fix the underlying problem rather than repeatedly repairing his machine. However, he has found HP very unresponsive to his requests, except the fact that the company does keep fixing the machine. Another reader, Nishant Mohan, has had similar problems with exactly the same model. His has failed four times now, and it takes a month each time to have it fixed.

Others have made similar comments, that HP is a very uncommunicative company, although often good, but slow, at fixing machines. This is also our experience. At the time of writing, HP has not satisfactorily resolved or answered any of the reader problems that we have passed on.

Another example: reader Dr. Sanjay Tharoor in Thiruvananthapuram purchased an HP Pavilion Laptop DV9312TX back in July 2007. After a year, his motherboard needed replacing, and this took a whole month, just as Mishant Mohan had described. The motherboard failed again, and the machine was returned to him, after a delay of more than one month, at the very beginning of April. I spoke to him a couple of weeks later, and the system had failed yet again, and he was just about to deliver it back to HP. He pointed out that one would expect better from a laptop that cost over Rs. 60,000! Indeed...

No wonder he feels "much frustration and anger", and also thinks that a better course than repairing the same system time and again would be to give him a different model. One cannot help but wonder if the HP engineers also consider this one to be unsuitable for the Indian market and climate.

We look forward to hearing some positive responses from HP to these and other similar issues. ■

Service problems? Write in the servicewatch@thinkdigit.com and we'll do our best to help to resolve them